Mallika Sarabhai knows resilience is an art form in itself. The actor, Bharatanatyam dancer and choreographer has made a living out of challenging the status quo and touching on socially relevant issues through her work for the Darpana Academy of Performing Arts, the institute founded by her parents, Vikram and Mrinalini Sarabhai. The Ahmedabad-based institute is celebrating its 75th year, and Sarabhai finds herself more driven than ever before. "I think all of us feel that the performing arts are perhaps the most persuasive language of getting through the walls of prejudice around us," Sarabhai said in New Delhi where she was presenting *Macbeth* at the Bharat Rang Mahotsav. "In the kind of fractured world we live in, it is important to somehow reach people's hearts and [find the] goodness in them."

It's both a blessing and a bane that Sarabhai doesn't know any other way. Her progressive bent and commitment to speak her mind has seen shows being cancelled, committed sponsorships fall through and funds and donations run dry. "I spend 85 per cent of my time on raising funds in an increasingly hostile space," she says. "Thankfully, there are benevolent people coming to our aid." One of them happens to be Italy's Nexion Surfaces which backed *Macbeth* (2023), a production that uses puppetry, projections and live music to look at the relevance of the Bard in today's time, and *Meanwhile Elsewhere* (2025), based on *Invisible Cities* by Italo Calvino. Yadavan Chandran, who has been Darpana's artistic director and plays Macbeth, says, "The core idea is to bring some meaningful change in people's lives and start a conversation. The need to question and argue comes through in everything we do."

That ethos is what Sarabhai grew up with. She believed that much like her accomplished mother Mrinalini, every artist would use their form "to talk about issues which bothered them and what needs to changed". That wasn't the case. After making her professional



***Meanwhile Elsewhere* is less an adaptation and more a metaphor "for our own cities", featuring characters like Kublai Khan and Marco Polo**



BOOKS

Carnatic Confiden

As an art form with a limited constituency of listeners and practitioners, the celebrated December season in Chennai is much awaited by Carnatic music aficionados. Giving in to the pleasure of listening and of a shared identification as a community, the concerts have commanded respect for creativity and rigour but also invited criticism for their social exclusiveness. Practitioners have, from time to time,come forward to share their views on the social biases inherent to the way the art form evolved over the past 80 years, some making peace with it and others critiquing it for perpetuating age-old caste and gender prejudices. In putting forward this criticism, musicians have adopted different strategies. For Sanjay Subrahmanyan, the choice was to both sing in Tamil and sing compositions of 19th-century composers like Ramalingam Swami as